▶ HIMACHAL PRADESH

KANGANA, NOT 'RUN OUT'



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As very much the native girl who grew up in her family haveli in Bhambla town, **Kangana Ranaut** doesn't have to try hard to switch on the Mandiyali dialect. Donning native attire, traipsing it up to Himachal's temples, doing the *nati* dance with local women...all that comes naturally to the dimpled star with a rapier-like tongue. Getting a bit of star power into politics is an old game. But then, the BJP may have got too much of a good thing happening with its celeb candidate from Mandi—with Kangana, stardom and power get along like a house on fire. It was to be expected that the B'wood A-lister would grab eyeballs among the public and in the media. But it's making life difficult for her poll managers. Partymen want the focus on issues. The crowds want the focus on themselves, posing with Kangana in countless selfies! Shooing them away wouldn't be a smart idea. With all the cameras around, there's also the pressure on her to look perfect. But BJP campaign managers crib that politics is a game where one doesn't always have vanity vans tagging along. Especially with Mandi being such a complex constituency, ranging down from the tribal areas of Barmaur all the way till the foothills of Mandi town. The good signs, BJP leaders say, are that she seems to be a quick learner. ■

▶ JHARKHAND

RISE OF THE FIRST LADY

Lest someone thinks Tihar is letting Hemant Soren live life hi-fi (complete with WiFi), the former Jharkhand CM's tagline on X now carries a disclaimer: "Account managed by wife **Kalpana Murmu Soren**." But of course, anyone who's been keeping an eye on the news knows Kalpana's role now transcends mere social media management; it's been taking on a shape and scale all its own. The INDIA bloc's 'Ulgulan Nyay rally' that she fronted in Ranchi on April 21 reinstilled the sense that the name 'Kalpana Soren' now carves out a small but distinctive niche nationally. She had already attained a degree of visibility at INDIA's Ramlila Ground rally on March

▶ KERALA

Pinarayi Unpl

